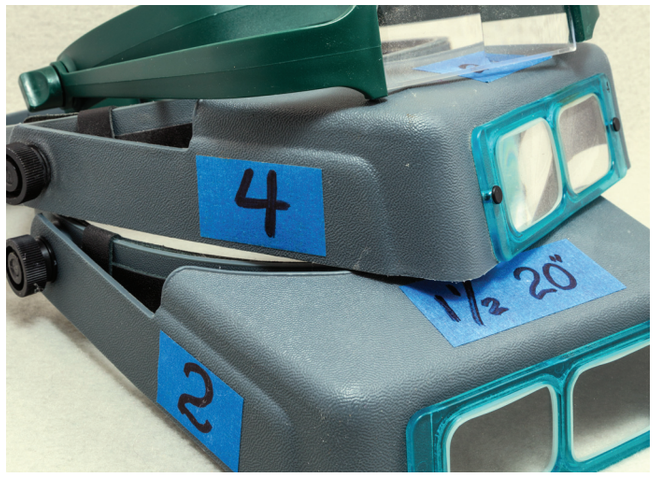
Helpful equipment

Good turning certainly requires good lighting. Even with good lighting in your turning area, when turning items that are small, additional light is always helpful. Task lighting on goose neck stands allows you to get the light positioned exactly where needed. Standard shop lighting is usually insufficient and located too far away to adequately illuminate your work in process. Get as much light as you can and get it in close. I find that magnifiers help as well. There are a host of companies that offer magnifying aids, whether they be mounted to your lathe and positioned as needed or worn on your head. The lathe-attached magnifiers work well and require little explanation. Mount them as needed provided you don't interfere with your work envelope or compromise safety. Headwear magnifiers will require that you use the proper focal length. You'll need the eye pieces to be focused effectively from your normal head position when turning to the work in process. This will allow for normal turning stance with the aid of magnification. Be certain that when using additional magnification that you still wear your PPE for eye protection.

You can never have too much light when turning small or miniatures: goose neck lamps allow for easy positioning



Magnifiers can be used – I favour a head-mounted one. Be certain you get the correct focal distance for ease of use

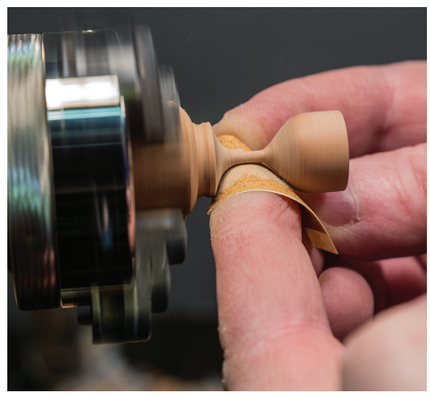
Turning and finishing process

There really isn't much in the process of turning smaller items that differs from the process of turning large items. If you are doing spindle work, you'll need to round your stock, shape and detail as needed, sand and finish, then part off. Being smaller and thinner, it will require a more delicate touch than usual. Flexing is a real issue to be dealt with to avoid chatter cutting. The usual good turning advice of sharp tools, high speed (being safer), and light touch is especially true. For faceplate-mounted work, you'll turn and reverse mount if needed.

Jamb chucks, cut to fit, work very nicely for smaller turnings. The only big difference is the delicacy. Vacuum doesn't lend itself well because of the small cross-sectional areas under vacuum; there isn't sufficient gripping force available. Tape and hot melt often will be of much assistance to your mounting issues. You'll need to have light touch and do far less sanding than usual. Even with finer grits of abrasive, you will easily lose detail and dimension with sanding. Keep sanding to a minimum. If your turnings are small enough, abrasives can't even be brought to bear. Sharp tools and light touch will help you get a quality result and minimise the need for sanding. Depending on your base material, you may not need any finish. Miniatures aren't often subject to the same wear that large works endure. As such, minimal finishing is needed and is often just to punch things up a bit. With hard dense materials, usually a quick buff with Micro-Mesh products will bring up sufficient shine. Another issue with finishing done with added chemicals is the clogging of any fine detail. Spray or wipe-on finishes will tend to gather in the bottom of sharp corners or detail, taking away all of the crispness you took effort to create.

When I jamb chuck miniatures, I cut them snug and then wet the wood to effect the grip. The jam chuck will swell to grip well

The jamb chuck allows for turning, sanding and finishing. Easy removal without damage once dry



Regular abrasives work on miniatures but slow speeds and light touch are in order. Only finer grits are needed with clean cuts

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